



Translation Team

PROFESSIONAL CLUB

Translation Handbook

A beginner's guide to Arabic–English translation

دليل الترجمة

مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

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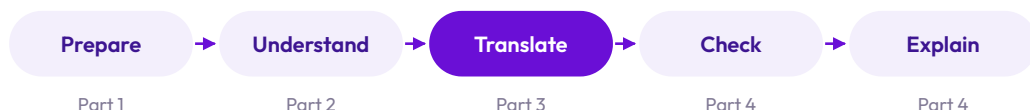
How to use this handbook

كيف تستخدم هذا الدليل

This handbook is for **beginners**. You do not need to know anything about translation to use it. It explains the basics of translating between English and Arabic, one step at a time.

The order of the book

The chapters follow the order in which a translator actually works:



Part 5 introduces useful tools and text types. Part 6 gives you exercises, with answers.

How each chapter works

Every chapter has the same simple layout, so you always know where to look:

1. **Introduction:** one sentence on what you will learn.
2. **A quotation** from a translator or scholar, in most chapters.
3. **In plain words:** the main idea, explained with an everyday comparison.
4. **Key words:** the new terms, with their Arabic equivalents.
5. **Explanation:** short sections with examples in both languages.
6. **Remember:** the most important points.

New to translation? Read the next page first: it walks you through one complete translation.

Signs used in this book

EN → AR	English source text, Arabic translation
AR → EN	Arabic source text, English translation
✓ and ✗	A good translation and a poor translation
SL / TL	Source language / target language (اللغة المصدر / اللغة الهدف)
ST / TT	Source text / target text (النص المصدر / النص الهدف)

Your first translation, step by step

ترجمتك الأولى خطوة خطوة

Before you read the chapters, watch the whole process once. Here is one short sentence, translated in the five steps this book follows.

It's raining cats and dogs, so the match has been cancelled.

1 Prepare Chapter 3

Ask the three questions. **Client:** a school. **Purpose:** to inform. **Audience:** Arabic-speaking parents. So the Arabic should be clear, simple and in standard Arabic.

2 Understand Chapters 5, 6 and 8

Raining cats and dogs is an **idiom**: it has nothing to do with animals and simply means “raining heavily”. *Match* here means a game: مباراة.

3 Translate Chapters 7–13

Word by word ❌ إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً، لذلك تمّ إلغاء المباراة.
By meaning ✅ ألغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة.

4 Check Chapters 15 and 16

Read the Arabic **without** the English. Is the meaning complete? ✅ Does it sound like natural Arabic? ✅ It starts with a verb and avoids the heavy تمّ.

5 Explain Chapter 17

“The idiom was translated by its meaning, because a word-for-word version would make no sense to Arab readers. The sentence was also rearranged so that it starts with a verb, as Arabic prefers.”

REMEMBER

- Prepare → Understand → Translate → Check → Explain. Every chapter in this book helps with one of these steps.

Chapter 1

What is translation?

ما الترجمة؟

Start here. This chapter explains what translation is, in the simplest possible terms.

“ *Rendering the meaning of a text into another language in the way that the author intended the text.*

Peter Newmark, *A Textbook of Translation* (1988), defining translation

IN PLAIN WORDS

Imagine a friend who only speaks Arabic asks you what an English sign says. You do not read the English words out one by one. You tell your friend what the sign **means**, in good Arabic. That is translation.

Key words

Source text (ST)	النص المصدر	The original text that you translate.
Target text (TT)	النص الهدف	Your translation.
Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	Turning a written text into another language.
Interpreting	الترجمة الشفهية	Turning speech into another language.

1.1 Translate the meaning, not the words

A beginner often replaces each word with a word from the dictionary. The result is usually wrong, because words do not match one to one. Look at this example:

English	Word by word ✗	Meaning ✓
Break a leg!	اكسر ساقاً!	بالتوفيق!

An English speaker says *Break a leg!* to wish someone good luck. The word-by-word version sounds like a threat, while *بالتوفيق!* carries the real meaning. So a translator does not copy words: a translator carries **meaning**.

1.2 No two languages match perfectly

Every language divides the world in its own way, so a translation can never be an exact copy. The translator's job is to get **as close as possible** to the meaning, especially the cultural meaning (Chapter 12). The Italian writer Umberto Eco described translation as *saying almost the same thing*.

1.3 The translator stands in the middle

The author writes for readers of one language. The translator reads and understands the text, then rewrites it for readers of another language.



If the reader does not understand the translation, the communication has failed, however “correct” each word may be.

REMEMBER

- Translate the **meaning**, not the words.
- A translation is always an approximation: aim for the closest natural meaning.
- Always think about the **reader**.

Chapter 2

The translator

المترجم

This chapter describes the skills a translator needs and the two ways a translator can work.

“ولا بدَّ للترجمانِ من أن يكونَ بيأنهُ في نفسِ الترجمةِ في وزنِ علمِهِ في نفسِ المعرفةِ، وينبغي أن يكونَ أعلمَ الناسِ باللغةِ المنقولةِ والمنقولِ إليها، حتى يكونَ فيهما سواءٌ وغايةً.

The translator's skill in expression must match his knowledge of the subject. He should know the language he translates from and the language he translates into better than anyone, until he masters both equally.

al-Jāhiz (d. 868 CE), *Kitāb al-Hayawān* · English version by the handbook team

IN PLAIN WORDS

A translator is like a bridge between two peoples. A bridge has to stand firmly on **both** banks. In the same way, a translator needs a firm footing in both languages and both cultures.

Key words

Commissioned translator	مترجم بتكليف	Someone who translates for a client, for example a freelancer.
Self-initiated translator	مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية	Someone who chooses a text to translate, with no client.
Bicultural	مُلمّ بالثقافتين	Knowing both cultures well.

2.1 What a good translator needs

- **Two languages.** You must be fluent in both the source language and the target language.
- **Two cultures.** Knowing the culture is as important as knowing the language (Chapter 12).
- **General knowledge.** Texts can be about anything, so a translator should be like a “walking encyclopedia”.
- **A rich vocabulary** (الخصيلة اللغوية), including idioms and fixed expressions.
- **Practice.** Skill grows with experience and with revising your own work.

2.2 Two ways of working

Translators work in one of two ways, depending on who chooses the text:

Commissioned translator	Self-initiated translator
A client asks you to translate a text. You follow the client's style and policy.	Nobody asks you. You choose the text yourself, for example a poem you love.

A **freelancer** works for different clients, so a freelancer is a **commissioned** translator.

2.3 Five good habits

1. **Be faithful** (الأمانة): do not add or remove meaning.
2. **Write naturally**: translation is rewriting, so the text must read as if it had been written in the target language.
3. **Revise** every translation (Chapter 15).
4. **Translate everything**, including titles, captions and footnotes.
5. **Keep learning**: read in both languages and build your vocabulary.

REMEMBER

- A translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Be faithful to the meaning and natural in the style.
- Revise every translation, even your best one.

Chapter 3

Before you translate: the brief

قبل أن تترجم: موجز الترجمة

This chapter shows you what to find out, and what to do, before you translate a single word.

“ *Function plus loyalty.*

Christiane Nord, *Translating as a Purposeful Activity* (1997): a translation must work for its purpose, and the translator must be loyal to the client, the author and the reader

IN PLAIN WORDS

A tailor asks who will wear a suit, and for what occasion, before cutting any cloth. A translator does the same: before translating, find out **who** the translation is for and **why** it is needed.

Key words

Translation brief

موجز الترجمة

The information you need before you start: who the client is, what the purpose is and who the readers are.

Target audience

الجمهور المستهدف

The people who will read your translation.

3.1 Ask three questions

Before you start, ask these three questions. The answers tell you **how** to translate.

Question	Why it matters
Who is the client? من هو العميل؟	Each client has its own style and policy.
What is the purpose? ما الغرض؟	Is the text meant to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain?
Who is the audience? من هو الجمهور؟	Experts or the general public? Adults or children?

3.2 Prepare in five steps

1. **Read the whole text twice** before you translate anything.
2. **Highlight** difficult words, idioms and names.
3. **Research** the topic, so that you understand what the text is about.
4. **Make a list** of the key terms (Chapter 14).
5. **Plan:** picture how the translation should sound.

3.3 An example brief

Here is a brief for a short news report. Notice how the last line turns the answers into decisions.

Text	A short news report
Client	KUNA (Kuwait News Agency)
Purpose	To inform
Audience	English readers interested in Kuwait
So...	Use a formal, neutral style and keep the headline short.

REMEMBER

- First find out the **client, purpose and audience**.
- Never start translating before you have read the whole text.

Chapter 4

English and Arabic are different

الفروق بين الإنجليزية والعربية

This chapter compares the two languages, so that you can avoid the most common beginner mistakes.

“*Languages differ essentially in what they must convey and not in what they may convey.*”

Roman Jakobson, “On Linguistic Aspects of Translation” (1959). For example, Arabic **must** say whether “you” is a man or a woman; English does not have to

IN PLAIN WORDS

Every language has its own habits. A sentence that is perfect in English can sound strange in Arabic if you copy its word order. Learn the main differences, and you will avoid most beginner mistakes.

Key words

Verbal sentence	الجملة الفعلية	A sentence that starts with a verb.
Register	المستوى اللغوي	How formal or informal the language is.
Modern Standard Arabic	الفصحى المعاصرة	The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.

4.1 The main differences

	English	Arabic
Word order	Subject first: <i>Sam ate the cake.</i>	Verb first: أكلَ سامُ الكعكةَ
Sentences	Short, with full stops	Long, joined with و، ف، ثمَّ
The verb “is”	Always written	Often not written, or يعلِّد
Synonyms	One word is enough	Pairs add emphasis: شجاعٌ مغوارٌ
“You”	One word for everyone	أَنْتَ (a man) or أَنْتِ (a woman)

	English	Arabic
Numbers 3–10	<i>three students</i>	Opposite gender: ثلاثة طلاب
Punctuation	, ; ?	، ؟

4.2 Which Arabic?

Use **Modern Standard Arabic** for written translation. Use a dialect (عامية) only if the client asks for it, for example in film subtitles.

4.3 Small words, big traps EN → AR

Some short English words look easy but do not mean what the dictionary's first entry says:

English	Arabic	Why
<i>He is in bed.</i>	إنه نائم	It means "asleep", not في السرير.
<i>As an officer, I...</i>	بصفتي ضابطاً...	Here <i>as</i> means a role, not ك.
<i>...to see the Roman ruins</i>	لزيارة الآثار الرومانية	Arabic says "visit".

4.4 Linking words that help Arabic flow EN → AR

English	Arabic	English	Arabic
<i>however</i>	غير أنّ	<i>therefore</i>	لذلك
<i>in addition</i>	بالإضافة إلى ذلك	<i>for example</i>	على سبيل المثال
<i>on the other hand</i>	من ناحية أخرى	<i>as a result</i>	ونتيجةً لذلك

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR:** start with the verb and join short sentences.
- **AR → EN:** start with the subject, drop repeated synonyms and split long sentences.
- Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: ، ؟

Chapter 5

Meaning, form and context

المعنى والبناء والسياق

This chapter explains the most important rule in translation: meaning comes before form.

“*Anything that can be said in one language can be said in another, unless the form is an essential element of the message.*

Eugene Nida and Charles Taber, *The Theory and Practice of Translation* (1969)

IN PLAIN WORDS

Think of meaning as water and form as the glass. You can pour the water into a different glass: the shape changes, but it is the same water. In translation, you may change the shape of a sentence, but never its meaning.

Key words

Form	البناء	The shape of the language: the words and how they are arranged.
Meaning	المعنى	The idea that the words express.
Denotation	المعنى المعجمي	What a word means in the dictionary.
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	The feeling a word carries: positive, negative, respectful...
Context	السياق	The words and the situation around a word or text.

5.1 Meaning comes before form

You may change the **structure** of a sentence, but you must never change its **meaning** (المعنى أهم من البناء).

English	Arabic	Why
Blair, Bush's poodle	بلير، تابع بوش	“Poodle” has no political meaning in Arabic, so we keep the idea: “an obedient follower”.
He is a heavy smoker.	يدخن بشراهة	The adjective becomes a verb, and the meaning stays the same.

5.2 Same meaning, different feeling

Words can share a dictionary meaning but carry different feelings. Choose the word with the right feeling:

Word	Feeling
مات <i>die</i>	Neutral
توفي <i>pass away</i>	Respectful
اغتيال <i>kill</i> · <i>assassinate</i>	"Assassinate" is political

5.3 What the speaker really means

Sometimes a speaker means more than the words say. Translate what the speaker **means**:

Words	Real meaning
أشعر بالحرّ	"Please turn on the air conditioning."
<i>It's freezing in here.</i>	"Please close the window."

5.4 Context tells you which meaning

Many words have more than one meaning. The words around them, the **context**, tell you which one is correct (لكلّ مقام مقال).

Word	Meanings
<i>bank</i>	مصرف (a financial bank) · ضفّة النهر (a river bank)
عين	an eye · a water spring · a spy
<i>case</i>	علبة (a box) · حالة (in medicine) · قضية (in court)

REMEMBER

- Change the form if you need to, but **never** change the meaning.
- Check the **feeling** of a word, not only its dictionary meaning.
- Let the **context** decide which meaning is correct.

Chapter 6

Analysing the text

تحليل النص

This chapter shows you how to study a text carefully before you translate it.

“ You begin the job by reading the original for two purposes: first, to understand what it is about; second, to analyse it from a ‘translator’s’ point of view.

Peter Newmark, *A Textbook of Translation* (1988)

IN PLAIN WORDS

A doctor examines a patient before prescribing medicine. A translator examines a text before translating it. This examination is called **text analysis**.

Key words

Text analysis	تحليل النص	Studying a text before translating it.
Genre	الجنس النصي	The type of text: news, contract, poem, advert...
Tone	النبرة	The writer’s attitude: neutral, critical, friendly...

6.1 Why analyse first?

- You understand the text better with every reading.
- You find the difficult parts in advance.
- You can choose your strategies before you start.
- You know which dictionaries and resources you need.

6.2 Analysis is not a summary

Analysis	Summary
Describes the text: who wrote it, for whom, why, and how.	Only says what the text is about.

When you are asked to analyse a text, do **not** summarise it.

6.3 Ten analysis questions

Answer these ten questions for every new text. The example answers are for a short KUNA news report.

Question	Example answer
1. Who wrote it, and who published it?	A KUNA reporter; KUNA
2. Who is the client?	KUNA's English service
3. What is the purpose?	To inform
4. Who is the audience?	Readers interested in Kuwait
5. What is the genre?	A news report
6. What is the field?	Politics
7. What are the tone and style?	Neutral and formal
8. Which terms need checking?	Official titles
9. Are there any cultural items?	Forms of address
10. Which strategies and resources will I use?	Mostly literal; a news-style guide

A blank copy of these questions is on the worksheet page at the back of the book.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis: if you call the tone formal, keep it formal.

Chapter 7

Equivalence

التكافؤ

This chapter explains how to find the expression in the other language that matches the original.

“*Translating consists in reproducing in the receptor language the closest natural equivalent of the source-language message, first in terms of meaning and secondly in terms of style.*

Eugene Nida and Charles Taber, *The Theory and Practice of Translation* (1969)

IN PLAIN WORDS

Equivalence means finding the expression in the other language that **does the same job**. Sometimes you can keep the same words, sometimes only the same function, and sometimes only the basic idea.

Key words

Equivalence	التكافؤ	Finding an expression in the target language that matches the source expression.
Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	Keeps the words and image of the original.
Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	Uses a different expression that does the same job .
Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	Keeps only the basic idea , in plain words.

7.1 One sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. A “dead letter” is a law or agreement that exists on paper but is never applied. Here are three ways to translate it. Which one would an Arab reader understand best?

Type	Arabic	Result
Formal	ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الحين	Same image, but unclear to readers
Functional	ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الحين	✓ A familiar Arabic idiom
Ideational	لم تُطبَّقْ الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الحين	Clear, but the image is lost

7.2 Another example

English	Functional	Ideational
<i>Ali is second to none in poetry.</i>	عليٌّ لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في الشعر	عليٌّ شاعرٌ متميزٌ

Both translations are correct. The functional one keeps the colour of an idiom; the ideational one is plainer.

REMEMBER

- First try to keep the form.
- If the form does not work, keep the **function**.
- If no idiom fits, keep the **idea**.

Chapter 8

Collocations and idioms

التلازم اللفظي والتعابير الاصطلاحية

This chapter explains word partners and fixed expressions, which must never be translated word by word.

“ You shall know a word by the company it keeps.

J. R. Firth, linguist (1957)

IN PLAIN WORDS

Some words are “friends” that always go together. In English we say *strong tea*, but in Arabic we say شاي ثقيل (“heavy tea”). If you translate the words one at a time, the friendship breaks and the result sounds wrong.

Key words

Collocation	التلازم اللفظي	Words that naturally go together, like <i>strong tea</i> .
Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	A fixed expression whose meaning you cannot guess from its words.
Proverb	المثل	A traditional saying.

8.1 Collocations EN → AR

Each English pair has its own Arabic partner. The last column shows what happens if you translate word by word:

English	Arabic	Do not write
pay attention	ينتبه	يدفع الانتباه
pay a visit	يقوم بزيارة	يدفع زيارة
strong tea	شاي ثقيل	شاي قوي
a fast colour	لون ثابت	لون سريع

8.2 Collocations AR → EN

Arabic	English
يساورني القلق	<i>I am growing worried</i>
قدّم استقالته	<i>he resigned</i>
اتّخذ قراراً	<i>made a decision</i>
عقد اجتماعاً	<i>held a meeting</i>

8.3 Idioms EN → AR

It's raining cats and dogs has nothing to do with animals: it means “raining heavily”. Translate the meaning of an idiom, or use an Arabic idiom with the same meaning:

English	Arabic
<i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i>	تمطر بغزارة
<i>over the moon</i>	يطير من الفرح
<i>to spill the beans</i>	أفشى السرّ
<i>I'm all ears.</i>	كلّي آذان صاغية
<i>Break a leg!</i>	بالتوفيق!

8.4 Proverbs AR → EN

Look for an English proverb with the same meaning. If there is none, give the meaning in plain English.

Arabic	English
كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار	<i>out of the frying pan into the fire</i>
رجع بخفي حنين	<i>he came back empty-handed</i>
عصفور في اليد خير من عشرة على الشجرة	<i>a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush</i>
لكلّ مقام مقال	<i>there is a time and a place for everything</i>

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Never translate an idiom word by word, but first check that it really is an idiom in this context.

Chapter 9

Literal and free translation

الترجمة الحرفية والترجمة الحرة

This chapter compares staying close to the original words with staying close to the reader.

“*Not word for word, but sense for sense.*”

St Jerome, translator of the Bible into Latin, in his letter to Pammachius (395 CE)

IN PLAIN WORDS

Imagine a line. At one end is **literal** translation, which stays close to the original words. At the other end is **free** translation, which stays close to the reader. A good translation usually sits somewhere in between.

Key words

Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	Keeps the words and changes only the grammar.
Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	Keeps the message, but not the form.
Communicative translation	الترجمة التواصلية	Aims to sound natural to the reader.

Literal

lose to the words

good translation is usually in between

Free

close to the reader

9.1 Literal translation: sometimes right, sometimes wrong

English	Arabic	Result
<i>The book is on the table.</i>	الكتاب على الطاولة	✓ Works
<i>to play a role</i>	يلعب دوراً	✓ Works
<i>to pay a visit</i>	يدفع زيارة	✗ Use يقوم بزيارة
<i>a long day</i>	يوم طويل	✗ Use يوم شاقّ

9.2 Free translation: not too free

A free translation may change the words, but it must not change the message:

English	Free translation	Result
<i>Appointing new staff should be based on equal opportunity.</i>	يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة	✓ Same message
<i>We have had heavy rainfall this winter.</i>	سيكون لدينا موسم زراعي مبشّر	✗ Adds a new idea

9.3 An old question

Translators have discussed “words or meaning?” for centuries. In the 14th century, the scholar al-Ṣafadī described two methods used by the translators of the Abbasid era. Some, such as Yūḥannā ibn al-Biṭrīq, translated **word by word**. Others, such as Ḥunayn ibn Isḥāq, read a whole sentence, understood it, and rewrote its **meaning**. Al-Ṣafadī judged the second method to be the better one.

9.4 Other kinds of translation work

Type	What it means
Sight translation	Reading a written text aloud in another language
Interpreting	Translating speech, during or after the speaker
Subtitling	Translating film dialogue within time and space limits
Localisation	Adapting websites and apps for another country

REMEMBER

- Use literal translation only when the result is natural.
- Free translation may change the form, but never the message.

Chapter 10

The seven translation procedures

إجراءات الترجمة السبعة

This chapter presents seven techniques for translating words and phrases.

“While translation methods relate to whole texts, translation procedures are used for sentences and the smaller units of language.

Peter Newmark, *A Textbook of Translation* (1988)

IN PLAIN WORDS

A procedure is a small tool for translating one word or phrase. Think of a toolbox with seven tools: you pick the tool that fits the job in front of you.

Key words

Method	منهج الترجمة	Your general approach to the whole text , e.g. literal or free (Chapter 9).
Procedure	إجراء الترجمة	A technique for translating one word or phrase .

The seven procedures

These procedures were described by the linguists Vinay and Darbelnet. They go from the one that stays **closest** to the original (1) to the **freest** (7). Try them in this order, and move down the list only when the result sounds wrong.

	Procedure	What it does	Example
1	Borrowing الاقتراض	Take the word as it is.	<i>computer</i> → كمبيوتر
2	Calque النسخ	Translate each part of the expression.	<i>skyscraper</i> → ناطحة سحاب
3	Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية	Translate word for word, when this is correct.	<i>The book is on the table.</i> → الكتاب على الطاولة
4	Transposition الإبدال	Change the word class, e.g. a noun becomes a verb.	<i>after his arrival</i> → بعد أن وصل

Procedure	What it does	Example
5 Modulation التحوير	Say the same thing from another point of view.	<i>It is not difficult.</i> → إنه سهل
6 Equivalence التكافؤ	Use a completely different fixed expression.	<i>Like father, like son.</i> → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد
7 Adaptation التكييف	Replace a cultural reference with a familiar one.	<i>like Romeo and Juliet</i> → كقيسٍ وليلى

10.1 The procedures in one sentence

A single sentence often needs several procedures:

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

English	Arabic	Procedure
<i>after his arrival</i>	بعد أن وصل	Transposition (noun → verb)
<i>press conference</i>	مؤتمر صحفي	Calque
<i>Sheraton</i>	شيراتون	Borrowing
<i>not impossible</i>	ممكنة	Modulation

REMEMBER

- A **method** is for the whole text; a **procedure** is for a word or phrase.
- Start with procedures 1–3. Move to 4–7 when the result sounds unnatural or unclear.
- Learn the names: in a commentary (Chapter 17) you **name** the procedure and explain why you used it.

Chapter 11

Translation strategies

استراتيجيات الترجمة

This chapter gives you practical solutions for words and expressions that are hard to translate.

“*Either the translator leaves the author in peace, as much as possible, and moves the reader towards him; or he leaves the reader in peace, as much as possible, and moves the author towards him.*

Friedrich Schleiermacher, “On the Different Methods of Translating” (1813), translated by André Lefevere

IN PLAIN WORDS

A strategy is your plan for solving a translation problem, for example a word that has no match in Arabic. This chapter gives you six ready-made plans, and shows you how to handle metaphors.

Key words

Strategy الاستراتيجية A planned solution to a translation problem.

11.1 Six useful strategies

Read the middle column first: it tells you **when** to use each strategy.

Strategy	Use it when...	Example
Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية	a target-language expression does the same job	<i>spill the beans</i> → أفشى السرّ
Cultural substitution الإبدال الثقافي	a cultural reference would mean nothing to the reader	<i>Romeo and Juliet</i> → قيس وليلى
Addition الإضافة	the reader needs extra information (common EN → AR)	<i>the Fed</i> → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي
Omission الحذف	words repeat the same meaning (common AR → EN)	شجاعٌ مغوارٌ → <i>very brave</i>

Strategy	Use it when...	Example
A more general word اللفظ الأعم	the target language has no exact word	<i>prawns / shrimps</i> → روبيان
Borrowing + explanation الاقتراض مع الشرح	a cultural word must be kept	الوقف → <i>waqf</i> (a charitable endowment)

Never add information to headlines, and never leave out real information.

11.2 Translating metaphors

A **metaphor** (الاستعارة) describes something as if it were something else: *She is a moon*. A **simile** (التشبيه) uses “as” or “like”: *She is like a moon*. To translate a metaphor, try these four steps in order:

Step	Example
1. Keep the image if both languages share it.	<i>She is a snake.</i> → إنها أفعى
2. Use an Arabic image if the English one is unfamiliar.	<i>the tip of the iceberg</i> → غيض من فيض
3. Change it into a simile.	<i>He is a rock.</i> → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته
4. Give the plain meaning (the last option).	<i>He is a chicken.</i> → إنه جبان

REMEMBER

- Choose a strategy for each problem, not one strategy for the whole text.
- For metaphors: keep the image, replace it, turn it into a simile, or explain it, in that order.

Chapter 12

Culture in translation

الثقافة في الترجمة

This chapter explains how to translate expressions that belong to one culture.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Words carry culture. “Summer” sounds lovely to an English reader, but a Kuwaiti reader thinks of 50°C heat. When an image carries a different feeling in the other culture, translate the **feeling**, not the image.

Key words

Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	Bringing a cultural meaning as close as possible to the reader.
Domestication	التوطين	Making the text feel local to the reader.
Foreignisation	التغريب	Keeping the text’s foreign flavour.

12.1 Same meaning, different image EN → AR

Each expression below has an Arabic partner with the same meaning but a different picture:

English	Arabic
<i>I’ve got the test in the bag.</i>	الامتحان في جيبي
<i>cut from the same cloth</i>	من طينة واحدة
<i>a scapegoat</i>	كبش الفداء
<i>like mother, like daughter</i>	أقلب الجرّة على فمها تطلع البنت لأُمّها

12.2 When climate changes meaning

English	Arabic	Why
<i>The news warmed my heart.</i>	أثلجَ الخبرُ صدري	In a hot climate, relief feels cold .

Shakespeare wrote: “*Shall I compare thee to a summer’s day?*” An English summer is mild and lovely, but a Gulf summer is harsh, so many translators choose spring: أَشْبَهَكَ يَوْمٌ رِبْعِيٌّ؟

12.3 Titles and institutions

Official titles differ from country to country. Translate the **job**, not the words:

English	Arabic
<i>the Home Office</i> (UK)	وزارة الداخلية
<i>the Secretary of State</i> (US)	وزير الخارجية
<i>the Chancellor of the Exchequer</i> (UK)	وزير المالية
<i>the Secretary of the Treasury</i> (US)	وزير الخزانة

12.4 Social expressions

For greetings, thanks and condolences, use the phrase people actually say **in the same situation**:

English	Arabic	Situation
<i>I'm sorry for your loss.</i>	عظم الله أجركم	Condolence
<i>Welcome! It's an honour.</i>	أهلاً وسهلاً، شرفتمونا	Hospitality
<i>Thank you for your hard work.</i>	الله يعطيك العافية	Thanks
<i>Many happy returns!</i>	عساكم من عواده	Gulf festive greeting

12.5 Domestication and foreignisation

When a text is full of cultural references, you can move in one of two directions:

Domestication التوطين	Foreignisation التغريب
Moves the text towards the reader. It feels local.	Moves the reader towards the text. It keeps a foreign flavour.
<i>a men's evening gathering</i>	<i>the diwaniya</i>

This is the choice Schleiermacher describes in the quotation at the start of Chapter 11.

REMEMBER

- Translate the **effect**, not the image.
- Use the expression a target-language speaker would use in the same situation.
- Decide whether the text should feel local (domestication) or foreign (foreignisation).

Chapter 13

When there is no equivalent

عندما لا يوجد مقابل

This chapter shows two solutions for words that have no equivalent: describing them, and creating new words.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Some words exist in only one language, because the thing they name exists in only one culture. English, for example, has no single word for الزكاة. You then have two choices: explain the word, or create a new one.

Key words

Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	Writing the sounds of a word in the other alphabet, e.g. زكاة → <i>zakat</i> .
Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	Explaining a word by describing its meaning.
Lexical creation	النحت المعجمي	Creating a new word in the target language.

13.1 Solution 1: describe the word

For cultural and religious words, first **transliterate** the word, then **describe** it in brackets or in a footnote. Do this only the first time the word appears.

Arabic	English
الزكاة	<i>zakat</i> (obligatory almsgiving in Islam)
التيّم	<i>tayammum</i> (ritual washing with clean earth when there is no water)
البسملة	<i>the basmala</i> (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
العِدّة	<i>‘idda</i> (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)

Use this as a **last option**, because it makes the text longer.

13.2 Solution 2: create a new word

New inventions and ideas need new words. Here are five ways Arabic has created them:

Method	Example
A new word	<i>blog</i> → مدوّنة
Translate each part (calque)	<i>smartphone</i> → الهاتف الذكي
Borrow the sounds	<i>radio</i> → راديو
Mix both	<i>cybersecurity</i> → الأمن السيبراني
A short explanation	<i>jet lag</i> → إرهاق السفر

13.3 Search before you create

English	Arabic
<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي
<i>cancel culture</i>	ثقافة الإلغاء
<i>global warming</i>	الاحترار العالمي

These new words already have accepted Arabic terms. A term from the Arabic language academies or UNTERM is always better than your own invention.

REMEMBER

- Describe a word only the first time it appears.
- Look for an existing term before you create a new one.

Chapter 14

Terminology

المصطلحات

This chapter shows you how to find, check and record specialised terms.

IN PLAIN WORDS

In law, medicine and other special fields, some words have one exact meaning. These are called **terms**. A wrong term can change a contract, so translators check every term and keep a list.

Key words

Term	المصطلح	A word with one exact meaning in a special field, e.g. law or medicine.
Term list	قائمة المصطلحات	A table of the approved terms for a project.

14.1 Four steps

1. **Find** the key terms in the text.
2. **Check** them in UNTERM, Arabterm, the language academies or the client's glossary.
3. **Record** each term, its translation and its context.
4. **Share** the list, so that the whole team uses the same terms.

14.2 A simple term list

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Not القانون الحاكم
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	Contract condition
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> = بند

REMEMBER

- Use **one term for one idea** all the way through the text.
- Never change a term “for variety”: a new word suggests a new meaning.

Chapter 15

Revising your translation

مراجعة الترجمة

This chapter shows you how to check your translation and avoid the most common mistakes.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Your first version is only a **draft**. Professional translators always read their work again, usually more than once, before they hand it in. Most mistakes are found at this stage.

Key words

Draft	المسودة	Your first version of a translation.
Revision	المراجعة	Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.

15.1 Revise in three readings

1. **Accuracy reading**, with the source text: is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Fluency reading**, without the source text: does it sound natural?
3. **Final check**: numbers, names, punctuation, titles and captions.

15.2 Common mistakes in Arabic EN → AR

These mistakes appear when English grammar is copied into Arabic:

Mistake	Wrong X	Right ✓
Subject first	الحكومة أعلنت...	أعلنت الحكومة...
Overusing قام بـ	قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت	زار الوزير الكويت
Passive with من قِبَل	تم افتتاح المعرض من قِبَل الوزير	افتتح الوزير المعرض
Numbers 3–10	ثلاث طلاب	ثلاثة طلاب
Spelling	إنشاء • مدرسه • الى	إنشاء • مدرسة • إلى
Punctuation	نعم, شكراً؟	نعم، شكراً؟

15.3 Common mistakes in English AR → EN

These mistakes appear when Arabic grammar is copied into English:

Mistake	Wrong ✗	Right ✓
Very long sentences	<i>...and he said and he added and...</i>	Split them with full stops.
Repeated synonyms	<i>brave and daring</i>	<i>very brave</i>
Extra “the”	<i>The life is beautiful.</i>	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>
Missing verb “to be”	<i>He in the office.</i>	<i>He is in the office.</i>
Arabic preposition	<i>He married from her.</i>	<i>He married her.</i>
No capital letters	<i>the minister of health</i>	<i>the Minister of Health</i>

15.4 Post-editing

Post-editing (التحرير اللاحق) means correcting a machine translation. It is now an important part of a translator’s work (Chapter 20).

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the source text.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

Chapter 16

Spotting risks

تقييم المخاطر

This chapter helps you find the places where a translation mistake could cause real harm.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Some mistakes are small, such as a missing comma. Others can cause real harm, such as a wrong dose in a medicine leaflet or a missing “not” in a contract. This chapter shows you where the dangerous mistakes usually hide.

Key words

Risk

الخطر

The chance that a translation choice causes a problem.

Check these eight risky places before you deliver a translation:

Risk	Example	What to do
Wrong term	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الحاكم	Check a specialised dictionary
Lost “not”	A negative sentence becomes positive	Compare sentence by sentence
Cultural image	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي	Use cultural approximation
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf / Arabian Gulf</i>	Follow the client; mention it in your commentary
Legal words	<i>shall</i> → سوف	Use the Arabic present tense
Numbers and dates	Wrong figure, Hijri or Gregorian date	Check every number
Wrong style	A dialect word in a formal report	Re-read with the brief in mind
Unclear word	علم: flag, knowledge or taught?	Read the words around it

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives and legal words every time.
- The higher the risk, the more carefully you check. Ask a second person if needed.

Chapter 17

Writing a commentary

كتابة التعليق على الترجمة

This chapter shows you how to explain and justify your translation choices.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A commentary explains your choices, like showing your working in a maths exam: **what** was difficult, **what** you did, and **why**.

Key words

Commentary

التعليق على الترجمة

A short text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.

17.1 Five parts for each problem

For each difficult point, answer these five questions in order:

1. **Problem:** what was difficult?
2. **Solution:** what did you write?
3. **Strategy:** which strategy or procedure did you use?
4. **Resource:** which dictionary or source did you check?
5. **Justification:** why is your choice right?

17.2 An example

The source text says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً، مميّناً، would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose حبراً على ورق. This is a **functional equivalent**. It was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of the news report.

REMEMBER

- Problem → solution → strategy → resource → justification.
- Write in the **third person** (“The translator...”), quote your examples and name the strategy.
- Always explain **why**.

Chapter 18

Language and ideology

اللغة والأيدولوجيا

This chapter explains how word choices can show a point of view, and what a translator should do about it.

“ *Language use as a form of social practice.*

Norman Fairclough, *Discourse and Social Change* (1992), on what “discourse” means

IN PLAIN WORDS

The same event can be described in different words, and each choice shows a point of view. Is a group of fighters called “rebels”, “militants” or “freedom fighters”? A translator must notice these choices and handle them carefully.

Key words

Ideology

الأيدولوجيا

A set of beliefs that affects how events are described.

Discourse analysis

تحليل الخطاب

Studying how language shows power and ideology.

18.1 No word is neutral

Word choices can show a point of view. Your translation can keep, soften or strengthen it, so choose carefully:

English	Arabic	Note
<i>regime · government</i>	نظام · حكومة	“Regime” is negative
<i>suicide bomber</i>	انتحاري / استشهادي	The choice depends on the client’s policy
<i>Protesters were killed.</i>	قُتل متظاهرون	The passive hides who did it

18.2 Three levels (Fairclough)

The linguist Norman Fairclough looks at every text on three levels, from the words on the page to society as a whole:

Level	Ask
1. The text	Which words show judgement? Who is the doer?
2. Its production	Who wrote it, and for which newspaper or organisation?
3. Society	Whose interests does it serve?

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words.
- Follow the client’s policy, and explain your choice in the commentary.

Chapter 19

Dictionaries

المعاجم

This chapter shows you which dictionaries to use and how to use them well.

“ *Dictionaries are like watches; the worst is better than none, and the best cannot be expected to go quite true.* ”

Samuel Johnson, author of *A Dictionary of the English Language*, as recorded by Hester Piozzi (1786)

IN PLAIN WORDS

A dictionary gives you **options**, not answers. You still have to choose the option that fits your context.

Key words

Bilingual dictionary	معجم ثنائي اللغة	Gives equivalents in another language.
Monolingual dictionary	معجم أحادي اللغة	Explains words in the same language.

19.1 Useful dictionaries

Dictionary	Use it for
Al-Mawrid (English–Arabic, Arabic–English)	Everyday words in both directions
Hans Wehr, <i>A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic</i>	Arabic words, organised by root
Al-Mu'jam al-Wasīṭ المعجم الوسيط	Checking Arabic meanings
Oxford Collocations Dictionary	Finding natural English word partners
Online dictionaries (e.g. Almaany)	Quick searches. Always double-check them.
UNTERM, Arabterm	Official and technical terms

19.2 Printed or digital?

Both kinds are useful. Know the strengths and weaknesses of each:

	Printed dictionaries	Digital dictionaries
Strengths	Edited by experts; reliable; full entries with examples	Fast; easy to search; updated with new words
Weaknesses	Slow to search; new words may be missing	Quality varies; some are written by anonymous users

With a digital dictionary, always check **who publishes it**. A digital version of a well-known printed dictionary is safer than an unknown website.

19.3 The three-check rule

1. Find options in a **bilingual** dictionary.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual** dictionary.
3. Check how the word is really used in a **text written in the target language**.

Example: for *fast colour*, a bilingual dictionary gives سريع، ثابت. An Arabic dictionary confirms that لون ثابت means “does not fade”. So the answer is لون ثابت.

REMEMBER

- Never take the first meaning a dictionary gives.
- Check in a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.

Chapter 20

Machine translation and AI

الترجمة الآلية والذكاء الاصطناعي

This chapter explains how to use machine translation and AI safely.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Machine translation and AI tools translate in seconds. They are useful helpers, but they make mistakes that beginners may miss. You, not the machine, are responsible for the final text.

Key words

Post-editing

التحرير اللاحق

Correcting machine output.

Hallucination

الهوسة

An AI invention, not in the source.

20.1 Useful or risky?

Useful for	Risky for
A first draft of simple texts Checking your ideas	Legal, medical and religious texts; idioms and poetry Private or confidential texts

20.2 Typical machine mistakes

English	Machine X	Correct ✓
<i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i>	إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً	تمطر بغزارة
<i>The doctor said she...</i>	قال الطبيب...	قالت الطبيبة...

20.3 Four rules

1. **You are responsible** for every word.
2. Never put a client's **private text** into a public AI tool.
3. **Check** terms, names, numbers, idioms and every “not”.
4. **Tell the client** if you used a machine or AI.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.

Chapter 21

Text types (genres)

أجناس النصوص

This chapter shows what matters most when translating the main types of text.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A recipe, a news report and a poem are written in very different ways. Each type of text, or **genre**, has its own rules, and your translation must follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.

Key words

Genre

الجنس النصي

A familiar type of text with its own rules.

Eight common genres

The middle column tells you what to pay most attention to. The examples show each genre in both languages.

Genre	What matters	Example
News	Facts, neutral tone, short headlines	<i>Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.</i> ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
Legal	Exact words; <i>shall</i> means an obligation	<i>This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.</i> تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
Political	Careful, sensitive words	<i>The two sides held frank and constructive talks.</i> أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.
Medical	No ambiguity; exact doses	<i>Take one tablet twice daily.</i> تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
Technical	Clear instructions, consistent terms	<i>Press and hold the power button.</i> اضغط مطولاً على زر التشغيل.
Literary	Feeling, voice, natural dialogue	<i>It has been a long day.</i> كان يوماً شاقاً.

Genre	What matters	Example
Poetry	Images, rhythm; more freedom	الخيلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني (al-Mutanabbi) <i>The horses, the night and the desert know me</i>
Advertising	Persuasion and rhythm	Save more. Smile more. وفر أكثر... وابتسم أكثر!

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre **before** you translate: each genre has its own rules.

Exercises

Practice

التمارين

The exercises get longer and harder, level by level. The chapter number after each sentence tells you where to look for help. Answers start on p. 46.

Level 1 Sentences

A. Translate each sentence. EN → AR

- | | | |
|---|--|--------|
| 1 | <i>She paid a visit to her grandmother.</i> | Ch. 8 |
| 2 | <i>The agreement has remained a dead letter.</i> | Ch. 7 |
| 3 | <i>He is a heavy smoker.</i> | Ch. 10 |
| 4 | <i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i> | Ch. 8 |
| 5 | <i>The Home Office issued a statement.</i> | Ch. 12 |

B. Translate each sentence. AR → EN

- | | | |
|----|-----------------------------|--------|
| 6 | رجع بخفي حنين. | Ch. 8 |
| 7 | أثلج الخبر صدري. | Ch. 12 |
| 8 | هو شجاع مغوار. | Ch. 11 |
| 9 | يساورني القلق بشأن النتائج. | Ch. 8 |
| 10 | قدم الوزير استقالته أمس. | Ch. 4 |

C. Each translation has one mistake. Find it and correct it.

- | | | |
|----|---|--------|
| 11 | <i>Pay attention, please.</i> → ادفع الانتباه من فضلك. | Ch. 8 |
| 12 | <i>The government announced new measures.</i> → الحكومة أعلنت إجراءاتٍ جديدة. | Ch. 4 |
| 13 | <i>I have three brothers.</i> → لديّ ثلاث إخوة. | Ch. 15 |
| 14 | <i>The life is beautiful.</i> → الحياة جميلة. | Ch. 15 |
| 15 | <i>He married from her last year.</i> → تزوّج منها العام الماضي. | Ch. 15 |

Level 2 Short texts

For each text: (1) write the brief (client, purpose, audience), (2) translate it, and (3) write two sentences explaining your main choice.

Text 2a EN → AR

All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Universal Declaration of Human Rights (United Nations, 1948), Article 1. When you have finished, compare your version with the official Arabic text.

Text 2b AR → EN

الخيْلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني . والسيفُ والرمحُ والقرطاسُ والقلمُ

al-Mutanabbi (d. 965 CE). Keep the rhythm of the list.

Text 2c EN → AR

*Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate.*

Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 (1609). Summer or spring? Explain your choice (Chapter 12).

Level 3 Full texts

Work through all the steps, as a professional would:

1. Answer the ten analysis questions (Chapter 6).
2. Translate the text.
3. Revise it using the checklists on p. 48.
4. Write a short commentary of about 150 words (Chapter 17).

Text 3a • News EN → AR

Health officials have urged residents to stay indoors between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. as temperatures are expected to top 50°C this week. “Heatstroke is not something to take lightly,” a Ministry of Health spokesperson said, advising people to drink plenty of water and to check on elderly neighbours. Meanwhile, shopping malls are expected to be packed as families seek relief from the heat.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Text 3b • Cultural news AR → EN

احتفلت الجمعية الثقافية مساء أمس بتكريم نخبة من المترجمين الشباب، وذلك في أمسية حضرها لفيف من الأدباء والأكاديميين. وأكد رئيس الجمعية في كلمته أن الترجمة جسر يصل الشعوب بعضها ببعض، مشيراً إلى أن العناية بالمترجمين الشباب واجب لا ترف. واختتمت الأمسية بقراءات شعرية مترجمة، وسط أجواء سادها الود والتقدير.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Answers

الإجابات

These are suggested answers. Often there is more than one good translation: any version that is accurate, natural and right for the reader is acceptable.

Level 1 Sentences

#	Suggested answer	Why
1	زارت جدّتها.	"Pay a visit" simply means "visit".
2	ظَلَّت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.	A functional equivalent (Chapter 7).
3	يدخّن بشراة.	Transposition: the adjective becomes a verb.
4	تمطر بغزارة.	An idiom is never translated word by word.
5	أصدرت وزارة الداخلية البريطانية بياناً.	The Home Office is the interior ministry.
6	<i>He came back empty-handed.</i>	The proverb's meaning, in natural English.
7	<i>The news warmed my heart.</i>	Arabic "cold" relief becomes English "warmth".
8	<i>He is very brave.</i>	English does not need two synonyms.
9	<i>I am growing worried about the results.</i>	A natural English collocation.
10	<i>The minister resigned yesterday.</i>	Subject first; قدّم استقالته = "resigned".
11	انتبه من فضلك.	Collocation
12	أعلنت الحكومة إجراءات جديدة.	Start with the verb.
13	لديّ ثلاثة إخوة.	Numbers 3–10 take the opposite gender.
14	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>	No "the" before general ideas.
15	<i>He married her last year.</i>	No Arabic preposition in English.

Level 2 Short texts

2a. يُولد جميعُ الناسُ أحراراً ومتساوين في الكرامة والحقوق، وقد وهبوا العقلَ والضمير، وعليهم أن يعامل بعضهم بعضاً بروح الإخاء.

Start with the verb (يُولد) and join the two sentences with و. Then compare with the official UN Arabic text.

2b. *The horses, the night and the desert know me, as do the sword, the spear, the paper and the pen.*

Keep the list of seven nouns. *Steed* and *parchment* would give a more classical tone.

2c. أَشْبِهَكَ يَوْمٌ مِنْ أَيَّامِ الرَّبِيعِ؟ أَنْتِ أَهْيَ مِنْهُ وَأَكْثَرُ اعْتِدَالًا.

Spring gives Arab readers the same pleasant feeling that summer gives English readers (Chapter 12).

Level 3 Tips

3a. *top 50°C* → 50 درجة مئوية · *not something to take lightly* → أمرٌ خطير (modulation) · *check on* → الاطمئنان على · *packed* → مكتظة

3b. Suggested opening: *Last night, the Cultural Society honoured a group of outstanding young translators at an evening attended by writers and academics.* Split the long sentence, keep the “bridge” image, and translate *الود والتقدير* as *a warm, appreciative atmosphere*.

Checklists

قوائم التحقق

Use these checklists with every translation. Tick each point as you go.

Before you translate

- ☐ I know the **client**, the **purpose** and the **audience**.
- ☐ I have read the whole text **twice**.
- ☐ I know the **genre** and the **tone**.
- ☐ I have marked difficult words, idioms, names and cultural items.
- ☐ I have made a list of **key terms**.
- ☐ I have my dictionaries and resources ready.

While you translate

- ☐ The **meaning** is the same as in the source.
- ☐ The **terms** are the same all the way through.
- ☐ The **style** suits the brief (formal or informal).
- ☐ The **collocations** and idioms sound natural.
- ☐ Cultural references are handled.

After you translate

- ☐ Nothing is missing and nothing is added.
- ☐ Every “not” is still there.
- ☐ Grammar, spelling and punctuation are correct.
- ☐ Numbers, names, dates, titles and captions are checked.
- ☐ I have read the translation once **without** the source.

Your commentary

- ☐ For each problem: problem → solution → strategy → resource → justification.
- ☐ I quote examples from the source and the translation.
- ☐ I write in the third person.

Analysis worksheet

ورقة تحليل النص

Photocopy this page and fill it in before you translate a new text (Chapter 6).

Text: _____ Direction: ☐ EN → AR ☐ AR → EN

1. Who wrote it, and who published it?

2. Who is the client?

3. What is the purpose?

4. Who is the audience?

5. What is the genre?

6. What is the field?

7. What are the tone and style?

8. Which terms need checking?

9. Are there any cultural items?

10. Which strategies and resources will I use?

Glossary

مسرد المصطلحات

The key terms in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the page where each one is explained.

Adaptation	التكييف	Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one.	23
Addition	الإضافة	Adding words the reader needs.	25
Analysis (text analysis)	تحليل النص	Studying a text before translating it.	15
Approximation	التقريب	Bringing the meaning as close as possible to the TL.	5
Borrowing	الاقتراض	Taking a word from the SL as it is.	23
Calque	النسخ	Translating each part of an expression.	23
Client	العميل	The person or organisation who asks for a translation.	9
Collocation	التلازم اللفظي	Words that naturally go together.	19
Commentary	التعليق على الترجمة	A text that explains and justifies translation choices.	35
Commissioned translator	مترجم بتكليف	A translator who works for a client.	7
Communication	التواصل	Understanding and being understood.	5
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	The feeling a word carries.	13
Context	السياق	The words and situation around a text.	13
Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	Bringing cultural meaning close to the TL reader.	27
Cultural substitution	الإبدال الثقافي	Replacing a cultural reference with a TL one.	25
Denotation	المعنى المعجمي	The basic dictionary meaning.	13
Draft	المسودة	Your first version of a translation.	32
Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	Explaining a word by describing it.	29

Discourse analysis	تحليل الخطاب	Studying how language shows power and ideology.	36
Domestication	التوطين	Making a text feel local to the reader.	25
Equivalence	التكافؤ	A TL expression that matches the SL one.	17
Foreignisation	التغريب	Keeping the foreign flavour of a text.	25
Form	البناء	The structure of words and sentences.	13
Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	Keeps the form of the original.	17
Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	Keeps the message, but not the form.	21
Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	Keeps the function of the original.	17
Genre	الجنس النصي	A type of text, e.g. news or a contract.	41
Hallucination	الهلوسة	AI output that is not in the source.	40
Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	Keeps only the basic idea.	17
Ideology	الأيدولوجيا	Beliefs that affect how events are described.	36
Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of its words.	19
Interpreting	الترجمة الشفهية	Translating speech.	5
Lexical creation	النحت المعجمي	Creating a new word in the TL.	29
Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	Keeping the words and changing only the grammar.	21
Machine translation	الترجمة الآلية	Translation done by software.	40
Meaning	المعنى	The idea that words express.	13
Method	منهج الترجمة	The general approach to a whole text, e.g. literal or free.	23
Metaphor	الاستعارة	Describing something as if it were something else.	25
Modern Standard Arabic	الفصحى المعاصرة	The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.	11
Modulation	التحوير	Changing the point of view.	23
Omission	الحذف	Leaving out words that repeat the meaning.	25

Post-editing	التحرير اللاحق	A human correcting machine translation.	40
Procedure	إجراء الترجمة	A technique for translating a word or phrase.	23
Proverb	المثل	A traditional saying.	19
Register	المستوى اللغوي	How formal the language is.	11
Revision	المراجعة	Checking and correcting a translation.	32
Risk	الخطر	The chance that a choice causes a problem.	34
Self-initiated translator	مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية	A translator who chooses a text, with no client.	7
Simile	التشبيه	A comparison with “as” or “like”.	25
Source language (SL)	اللغة المصدر	The language of the original text.	3
Source text (ST)	النص المصدر	The original text that you translate.	5
Strategy	الاستراتيجية	A planned solution to a translation problem.	25
Target language (TL)	اللغة الهدف	The language of the translation.	3
Target text (TT)	النص الهدف	Your translation.	5
Term	المصطلح	A word with a special meaning in one field.	31
Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	Transferring the meaning of a written text.	5
Translation brief	موجز الترجمة	Client, purpose and audience.	9
Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	Writing a word’s sounds in the other alphabet.	29
Transposition	الإبدال	Changing the word class, e.g. noun → verb.	23
Verbal sentence	الجملة الفعلية	A sentence that starts with a verb.	11

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ملاحظات

ملاحظات

“Translate the meaning, not the words.”

ترجم المعنى، لا الكلمات.

This handbook introduces beginners to translating between English and Arabic, step by step, from preparing to translate to checking and explaining the result. Each chapter follows the same simple layout, with clear examples in both languages and exercises with answers.